What's new

How to Formalize All of Mathematics

Terence Tao · 16 October 2026

https://terrytao.wordpress.com/2026/10/16/how-to-formalize-all-of-mathematics/

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Jeremy Avigad, Kevin Buzzard, Johan Commelin, Rémy Degenne, Kim Morrison, Oliver Nash and Adam Topaz have written a blog post over on Kevin Buzzard's blog entitled "How to Formalize All of Mathematics", regarding recent proposals to automatically formalize the entirety of the mathematical literature. The issues regarding formal mathematics are parallel to those regarding informal mathematics, in particular the tradeoff between speed, scale, and understanding when one prioritizes the production of output over all other desiderata, and the blog post is largely focused on this tradeoff.

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We are not robots, and empty formalism ≠ understanding. Truly great mathematics is a living art. Who cares about a proof without any insight?

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This misses the point of formalization. Who cares about a "proof" which isn't a proof?